Since each organism can eat multiple organisms and be eaten by multiple organisms, a food web is a much more realistic scheme of the transfer of energy within an ecosystem (Figure 7.4).

Food chains and food webs are found in both terrestrial and aquatic ecosystems.

Organisms in a food chain or food web are linked and dependent on one another for survival. If organisms in one trophic level become threatened, it impacts the organisms in other trophic levels. Primary consumers get less food due to loss or destruction of habitat.

This in turn means less primary consumers for secondary and tertiary consumers to feed on. The plant and animal species in such an environment could become endangered or even extinct. For this reason, it is vital that an ecosystem remains balanced containing an appropriate proportion of producers and consumers.

7.3.3 Energy Flow in an Ecosystem

Energy in an ecosystem flows from producers to consumers. The available energy in a food chain decreases with each step or trophic levels up in the food chain. As such, there is less energy available to support organisms at the top of the food chain. That is why the tertiary

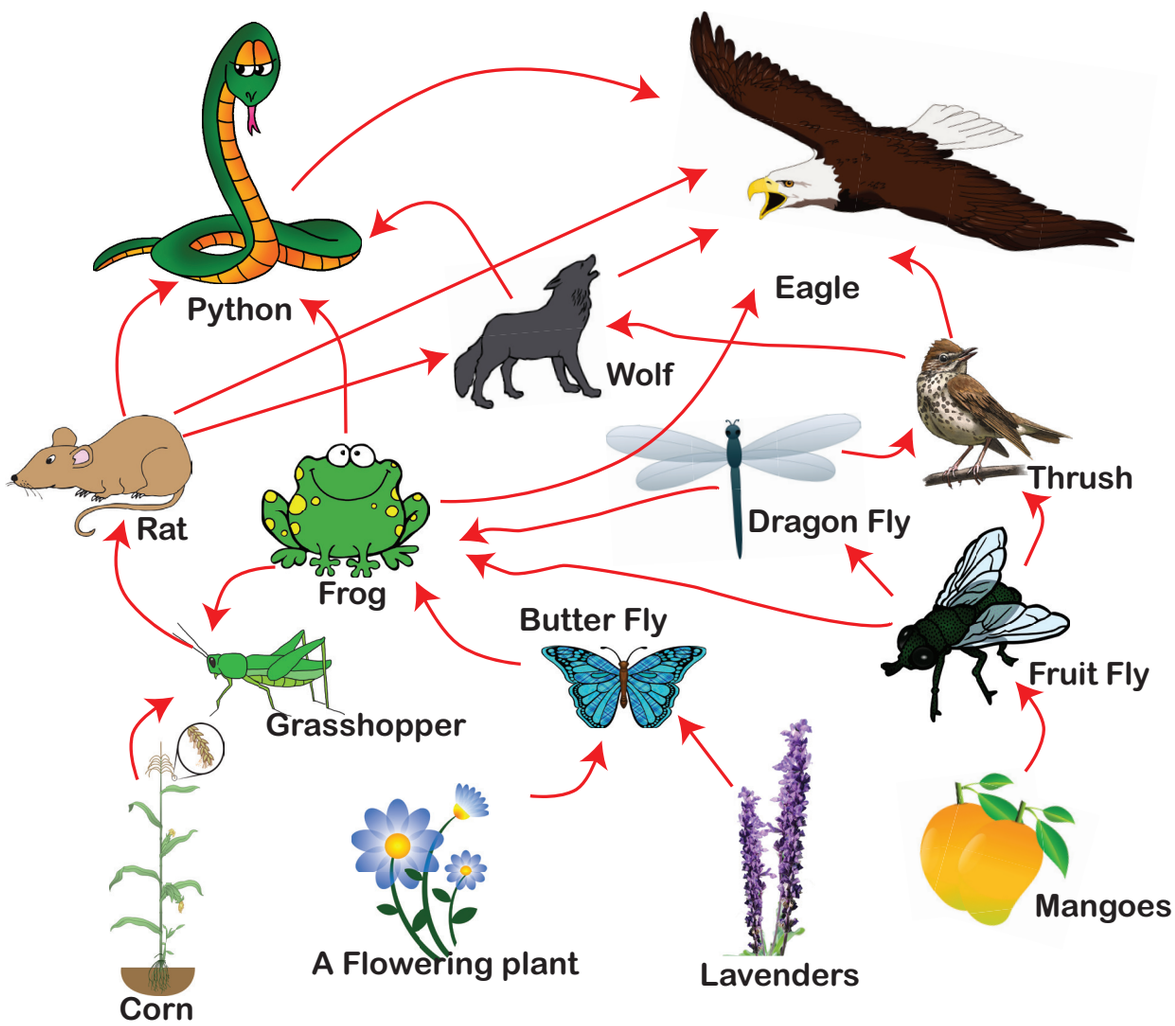


Figure 7.4 Food web

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